

VICE-LIKE HOLD
Deepaly and Akshat Sharma after their arrest in Jodhpur



PANKAJ TIWARI

Ravinandan Tiwari had an FIR lodged when a nude woman recorded a call with him and later demanded Rs 50,000. The same month, Harendra Singh Gurjar of the zila Congress Sewa Dal lodged a similar complaint in the city.

Pragya Thakur could be the first case of a woman being targeted. One thing that has been established is that the Mewat region, from where the suspects were arrested, is now a hub of innovative cyber crimes, including "virtual honeytraps".

"Criminal minds keep finding new ways to make money. Sextortion is the new trend," says Ashok Rathore, additional DGP, Special Operations Group (SOG), Rajasthan. Looking at a map on CyCaps, a portal developed by the Telangana Police to track suspected telephone numbers used in cyber crimes, he says the location tracker shows a very high density of such numbers active in the seven police districts of the extended Mewat region. These are Bharatpur, Alwar and Bhiwadi in Rajasthan, Agra and Mathura in UP, Nuh and Mewat in Haryana and parts of Delhi. A number of criminals have been arrested in sex-and-blackmail cases from this region.

In 2020, an interstate cooperation cell was set up for these seven districts, with the respective IGs and SPs of police from all four states on board. Many mobile phones active in these districts use SIM cards issued in Odisha, West Bengal and Bihar, but the coordinated efforts have started showing results.

On February 9, Delhi Police arrested Samaydeen, 28, and Munfed, 26, from the Mewat region. The duo are accused of cheating at least 200 people through online honeytraps similar to the one used on the BJP MP; they had Rs 22 lakh in their account. In October last year, Nasir from Bharatpur district was arrested on similar charges by Delhi Police. In December 2021, Delhi Police nabbed Neeraj from Bahadurgarh in Haryana, who ran a similar gang. His gang had at least 12 victims from whom they had extorted Rs 1 crore. Gang members created social media accounts using fake IDs, cultivated potential victims and lured them into physical interactions with women accomplices. Sextortion cases are piling up in Rajasthan. Police are investigating a number of complaints from resident doctors of Jaipur's state-run SMS Hospital, who have been targeted virtually by anonymous callers. In November last year, the SOG chargesheeted five accused, including two from Alwar, for making an objectionable video of a prominent personality and then extorting money.

Police say while victims of cyber financial frauds were spread all over, a lot of the targets of sextortion are based in the southern states. And it is difficult to trace these cyber criminals. Although CyCaps generates a lot of data, which includes social media profiles, IMEI numbers of handsets used and interlinked phone numbers, it is still not enough to nail down a suspect as multiple police stations, banks and payment portals are involved.

Rajasthan DGP M.L. Lather says that while the police are using the latest digital technology to catch such criminals, "the people must be careful interacting with strangers online and must report any suspicious numbers/ activities immediately". Since in many cases victims have only interacted online with the callers, officials say the "shame element is less than in physical honeytrap cases". (In the 2016 Akshat Sharma gang case, only five of the 30 victims came forward to lodge a complaint. Even the prominent Congress leader, who paid a ransom of Rs 20 lakh, refused to join the investigation.)

A bigger concern for cops now is children being compromised. They fear that with children having ready access to mobile phones and internet, extortionists may start targeting them. "If they could do it to a woman MP, they can do it to anyone," says a senior police officer. The Union ministry of home affairs runs the CyberTipline, which alerts state police about those uploading suspected videos of child pornography, rapes, etc. and those accessing such material. Between April 2020 and June 2021, Rajasthan police received 31,086 such inputs. The Cyber Crime Unit referred 82 cases to the districts. ■

CRIME TRACKER

The CyCaps portal's readings suggest that many of the accused in sextortion cases were from the Mewat region

